

# SIGNAL-STACKING

## How Digital Personas Manufacture Credibility

### A Field Guide & One Expanded Case Study

The Vocabulary, Mechanics, and Layered Anatomy of Manufactured Online Credibility

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Case Study · RadioReach.us / Zazie Productions LLC

*Compiled from open-source investigation: WHOIS & DNS records, PDF forensics, cross-platform footprint analysis, and press-network tracing. Prepared as an educational reference on persuasion mechanics, credibility signaling, and self-promotion tactics in digital creator economies.*

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# Introduction & Methodology

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## 1.1 Why This Document Exists

This guide grew out of a real consumer-protection question — a \$20 purchase of a “verified radio station contact database” that turned out to contain fabricated sample data and a decade-old, recycled contact list. Investigating the seller behind that product led to a broader discovery: an elaborate, genuine-but-inflated online persona built through years of small, individually reasonable actions. The case forms a useful field guide to how a real person — not a criminal organization — can construct outsized credibility using free or cheap tools that are available to anyone.

The goal of this document is not to condemn its subject personally. It is to name the mechanisms clearly, give each one its real industry term, and show — concretely, with receipts — how each layer of a persona is built, so the reader can recognize the same patterns anywhere else they appear: an Etsy seller, a LinkedIn “thought leader,” a crypto founder, a wellness influencer, or a coworker's side hustle.

## 1.2 Investigation Methodology

The findings in this guide were produced using only free, publicly accessible tools:

- **WHOIS lookups** — to establish domain registration dates, registrants, and physical addresses.
- **DNS / MX record checks** — to test whether email domains in a “verified contact list” could technically receive mail at all (a null-MX record or NXDOMAIN result proves a hard bounce mathematically, without sending a single email).
- **PDF forensics** — extracting and analyzing the actual delivered product (not just the marketing page) to compare advertised samples against real contents, and to fingerprint the data's age via defunct company domains (e.g., email addresses ending in a company name that was rebranded over a decade ago).
- **Cross-platform footprint mapping** — searching a name/brand across IMDb, LinkedIn, Bandcamp, Spotify, streaming aggregators, playlist trackers, business registries, and press archives to see which claims are independently corroborated versus self-reported only.
- **Byline & template pattern analysis** — comparing multiple “press” articles about the same subject (or written by the same byline about unrelated subjects) to detect content-mill patterns.
- **Wayback Machine / archive checks** — to establish how new a domain or persona actually is.

### ■ INSIGHT — Nothing here required special access.

Every technique used to investigate these personas is available to anyone with a web browser and about two hours of patience. The asymmetry isn't in the tools — it's that almost nobody actually uses them before making a \$20 purchase or extending professional trust.

# RadioReach.us / Zazie Productions LLC

## 2.1 The Product & The Sales Page

RadioReach.us sold an “18,000+ radio station contacts” PDF database to independent musicians for \$20 (marked down from a listed \$49), plus a separate “Australian add-on.” The landing page used a textbook direct-response sales structure: a countdown timer (“Founder price ends in...”), a fake scarcity counter (“37/250 licenses left”), a live-visitor counter (“214 artists viewing this page”), a stacked-value table inflating the product to a claimed “\$742 value,” and five-star testimonials attributed to named “verified buyers.”

The seller's own framing was that of a fellow struggling independent artist: “I'm an independent artist too... I built this because I had to do the research myself and refuse to gatekeep it.”

## 2.2 What The Forensic Audit Found

- **Bait-and-switch sample data.** The pre-purchase “live sample” listed “Derrick Monroe” as WGCI-FM's Music Director and “Shelby Harmon” as KUTX's Program Director. Neither name exists in the real, delivered PDF (which instead lists “Kris Kelley” and blank/other names) and neither matches the stations' actual current staff (Derrick Brown at WGCI; Matt Reilly at KUTX).
- **Domain deliverability testing (DNS/MX):** Running MX-record checks against all 4,899 unique email domains across the 18,020-row file found roughly **13% were mathematically guaranteed to bounce** (null-MX or non-existent domains), including 447 emails on two domains that explicitly refuse all mail.
- **Data staleness:** The single largest email domain in the file (1,138 entries) was @clearchannel.com — Clear Channel Communications rebranded to iHeartMedia in **2014**. Zero @iheartmedia.com addresses exist anywhere in the file. Other major domains (@citcomm.com, @coxradio.com) belong to companies that stopped existing under those names 10–15 years ago.
- **Named-contact accuracy:** A spot check of 4 major-market entries (WGCI, KUTX x2, KIIS-FM) found **4 of 4 were outdated or wrong** when checked against current, publicly verifiable station staff.
- **The “Australian add-on”** turned out to be a 2-page, unformatted list of generic newsroom/press inboxes (e.g., *newsroom@2gb.com*) — the wrong contact type entirely for music submissions — closely matching the content of a free, publicly available 2015/2018 union media-contacts guide, including one entry pointing to a domain (mytriple.com.au) that does not exist at all.

### ■ INSIGHT — “Verified” can be technically true and still misleading.

The seller's FAQ claimed “10,372 individually verified deliverable addresses.” A domain having a working mail server (deliverable) is a completely different claim from the named person still holding that job (accurate). This case blurred this exact distinction to sound more rigorous than the underlying process was.

## 2.3 The Persona Behind The Product

The registrant, Zazie Kanwar-Torge (Zazie Productions LLC, Asheville, NC), is a real, independently verifiable person with a consistent multi-year digital footprint: an IMDb page (composer/sound designer credits on several short films), a LinkedIn profile, a Behance page, a Muso.ai songwriting credit page, a 2019 Pulitzer Center youth essay listing (age 13, Asheville, NC — matching the domain's WHOIS address), and a 4-year (2020–2024) volunteer Music Intern role at Asheville FM, a real nonprofit community radio station.

Self-description across platforms is consistent: “autistic polymath,” “multidisciplinary creator,” “outsider artist,” styled as a “Gen-Z Frank Zappa.” A satirical persona, **@WellMeaningNeurotypicals**, self-reports 28k followers and 10M+ views and has a commercially distributed 2022 single of the same name.

## 2.4 The Parallel Ventures

- **Music/scoring career:** 15+ Bandcamp releases since 2020, distributed simultaneously to Spotify, Apple Music, and Deezer (almost certainly via a distributor such as DistroKid/TuneCore/CD Baby — one upload, automatic multi-platform push).
- **Spotify playlist curation:** A “Goa Trance/Psy Trance” playlist with 31,684 followers, independently confirmed via a third-party playlist-tracking site — a genuinely earned niche reputation, built over years.
- **Groover paid curator/reviewer profile** — offering paid feedback and playlist consideration to other independent artists, the same ecosystem RadioReach's marketing claims to help artists escape.
- **Gumroad & itch.io storefronts** selling small, cheap digital assets with dramatic, esoteric branding: “The Forbidden Canticles,” “World's Strangest Plug-in Mega-Vault: 200+ Banned, Cursed, and Unhinged VSTs,” “Aeonic Codemason BlackOps Protocols.” The word “Vault” recurs in both this catalog and the RadioReach branding — a reused naming convention across otherwise unrelated products, suggesting one author writing copy for multiple audiences.

## 2.5 The Press Network

Bio pages cite placements in outlets including **PR ON THE GO** (an SEO “expert roundup” blog in which Zazie's quote appears alongside a mobile-notary CEO and a mushroom-supplement marketer), **In Your Eyes Ezine** (accessed via SubmitHub, a pay/credit-based music-blog submission platform), several small open-submission literary zines/anthologies, and a quote in a Viral Nation marketing blog post (likely sourced via a journalist-matching platform such as Qwoted/HARO, which anyone can join for free).

Critically, a feature titled “Zazie Productions: The Underground Polymath Redefining Experimental Music” appears on **GrammyWeekly.com** — a site with no affiliation to the Recording Academy or the Grammy Awards. The byline, “Angelina Joy,” is the same name used across dozens of unrelated GrammyWeekly features (Beyoncé, a professional wrestler's daughter, random unsigned hip-hop singles) — the signature of a content-mill house byline, not a beat reporter.

## 2.6 Tiered Legitimacy Breakdown

| Term                                         | Definition                                                                                                    | Real-World Example                                            | In This Case Study                                                                                                                                                            |
|----------------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Tier 1 — Real gatekeeping</b>             | Selection required real curatorial judgment by an accountable institution; meaningful rejection risk existed. | A university's tenure review; a juried gallery show.          | Black Mountain College Museum commission (2021); Pulitzer Center youth-essay finalist; niche netlabel compilation placement alongside artists with real underground standing. |
| <b>Tier 2 — Earned, low-fee, high-effort</b> | Low or no financial barrier to entry, but real skill/taste/persistence required to reach the stated scale.    | Growing a YouTube channel organically over years.             | 31,684-follower Spotify curator playlist, independently verified by a third-party tracker; AFM union membership.                                                              |
| <b>Tier 3 — Self-serve / pay-adjacent</b>    | Anyone who submits, pays, or fills out a form is published; no independent editorial vetting occurs.          | A "top 10 under 30" listicle that runs anyone who pays a fee. | GrammyWeekly.com feature; PR ON THE GO expert roundup; SubmitHub-driven blog placement; Gumroad reviews.                                                                      |

## 2.7 Domain, Website & Consumer-Trust Infrastructure

The persona and product were also shaped by the speed and incompleteness of the underlying web infrastructure. At the time of the initial audit, RadioReach looked like a mature direct-response product while several basic trust and accountability surfaces were either new or missing.

| Term               | Definition                                                                                                            | Real-World Example                                                                       | In This Case Study                                                                                     |
|--------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Domain age</b>  | radioreach.us was registered on August 1, 2026.                                                                       | A newly registered storefront can look older through polished design and confident copy. | The brand had little independent operating history when strong scale and verification claims appeared. |
| <b>Ownership</b>   | WHOIS records connected the domain to Zazie Productions rather than an anonymous shell.                               | Identifiable ownership increases accountability but does not validate the product.       | The seller was real and reachable; the data claims still required separate testing.                    |
| <b>Legal pages</b> | Privacy, terms, contact, refund, about, and related policy routes returned page-not-found responses during the audit. | Missing policies weaken consent, refund clarity, and customer recourse.                  | A refund promise existed in sales copy without a complete legal/support framework around it.           |
| <b>Checkout</b>    | Stripe-related assets were present.                                                                                   | Using a mainstream payment processor is safer than collecting raw cards directly.        | This reduced card-handling risk but did not resolve accuracy or dark-pattern concerns.                 |
| <b>Interface</b>   | Countdowns, scarcity, live viewers, value stacks, and buyer testimonials were layered together.                       | A mature conversion surface can make a new operation feel institutionally established.   | Presentation maturity substantially exceeded evidence and policy maturity.                             |

### ■ INSIGHT — Operational maturity and visual maturity were out of sync.

RadioReach had the visual grammar of a mature product — precise metrics, urgency, social proof, checkout, and an organized PDF — before it had the documentation, update process, legal pages, or verification record normally expected behind those signals.

## 2.8 Original PDF: Deeper Data Forensics

The original 401-page file did contain roughly the advertised number of rows. The deeper problem was that row existence, domain infrastructure, mailbox acceptance, role accuracy, and current human employment were treated as if they were one verification category.

| Term                        | Definition                                                                                                      | Real-World Example                                                             | In This Case Study                                                                |
|-----------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Unique domains</b>       | 4,899 across approximately 18,020 rows.                                                                         | Large domain variety can create the impression of broad independent sourcing.  | The count did not establish current mailbox or staff accuracy.                    |
| <b>Legacy concentration</b> | 1,138 @clearchannel.com rows; hundreds more on Cumulus, Citadel, Entercom, Cox, Gap, and consumer-mail domains. | Historic corporate domains fingerprint the age and lineage of a list.          | Clear Channel rebranded in 2014; citcomm.com and coxradio.com returned null MX.   |
| <b>MX alive</b>             | 14,444 rows, about 80.2%, were on domains with live mail infrastructure.                                        | A live domain may still reject the exact mailbox.                              | This was the strongest domain-level result, not proof of 14,444 reachable people. |
| <b>NXDOMAIN</b>             | 1,314 rows, about 7.3%.                                                                                         | The domain did not exist.                                                      | Guaranteed failure at the domain level.                                           |
| <b>Null MX</b>              | 688 rows, about 3.8%.                                                                                           | The domain explicitly declares that it accepts no email.                       | Guaranteed failure even though the domain itself may resolve.                     |
| <b>No usable MX</b>         | Additional rows had no MX, no A record, nameserver errors, or timeouts.                                         | Infrastructure uncertainty should not be presented as verified deliverability. | The total mathematically hard-fail share was roughly 13%.                         |

The sales sample was more damaging than ordinary staleness because it was not merely an old excerpt. WGCJ-FM and KUTX examples used names and roles that did not match the delivered file. The delivered file itself then contained different historic contacts. The sample therefore created a second, cleaner product image that the buyer could not locate in the purchased artifact.

### ■ INSIGHT — False precision operated at two levels.

The exact totals — 18,020 rows and 10,372 verified emails — felt audited. But the category boundaries were unstable, and the public sample did not trace cleanly into the shipped file. Precision in counting cannot rescue a category that was never consistently defined.

## 2.9 The 8,430-Row Mega-Document

A later consolidated CSV appeared newer and more structured than the 401-page PDF, but its source labels revealed that most of the scale still came from weak or unverifiable buckets. The file had 8,430 rows and 17 columns, yet only 521 rows included a source URL.

| Term                                       | Definition                                                           | Real-World Example                                                               | In This Case Study                                                                        |
|--------------------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>2026 active U.S. station file</b>       | 7,234 rows — 85.8% of the mega-document.                             | A current-sounding source label implies fresh verification.                      | Spot checks found outdated roles and structurally wrong entries; the bucket was excluded. |
| <b>Web-published station lead</b>          | 432 rows.                                                            | A public web appearance can be useful when the page is traceable.                | The bucket lacked enough reproducible sourcing and was excluded.                          |
| <b>RadioWorld DJ email list</b>            | 401 rows.                                                            | A trade-adjacent source name can confer authority.                               | The records were not sufficiently verifiable and were excluded.                           |
| <b>2023 College Radio Directory</b>        | 143 rows.                                                            | Older but use-case-relevant directories can contribute if filtered and labeled.  | Retained only after domain checks and consumer filtering.                                 |
| <b>Official submission / station crawl</b> | Official pages and station-site crawls formed smaller buckets.       | Direct station publication is materially stronger than an opaque inherited list. | Kept where email domains and record structure survived checks.                            |
| <b>Trusted remainder</b>                   | 259 candidate rows across 174 domains; 220 survived domain cleaning. | Smaller verified buckets often carry more value than the large opaque one.       | Misspelled, truncated, dead, and malformed domains were removed.                          |

Mailbox sampling exposed the gap between live domains and live inboxes. In a 145-address sample, 56 returned SMTP rejection, 45 could not be conclusively tested because of connection failure, 27 were accepted, 15 had no MX, and 2 were greylisted. Among conclusive station-branded checks, the rejection share was roughly 68%. The sample was not a census, but it directly contradicted a broad individual-deliverability impression.

### ■ INSIGHT — A source label can itself become a credibility signal.

Calling a bucket “2026 active” did not make its contacts current. The label sounded like a method, but no reproducible verification trail supported the overwhelming majority of those rows.

## 2.10 Contact-Type & Use-Case Confusion

Many records were real in a narrow sense but wrong for the promised task. The audit therefore had to distinguish station reality from outreach usefulness.

| Term                               | Definition                                                                             | Real-World Example                                           | In This Case Study                                                                       |
|------------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>FCC Main Studio Contact</b>     | A legally filed station-level contact from a government record.                        | Useful for establishing a genuine station and contact route. | Not evidence that the person programs music or accepts artist submissions.               |
| <b>Shared corporate compliance</b> | Addresses used across many stations for legal, disability, or public-file obligations. | Technically real and often deliverable.                      | Removed from the consumer MVP because they are not practical artist-outreach routes.     |
| <b>Newsroom / press</b>            | Generic contacts for news tips and media inquiries.                                    | Appropriate for publicists pitching newsworthy stories.      | Different use case from music rotation; the Australian press list was excluded.          |
| <b>Internet / webcast station</b>  | Station-published email from an online directory or listing page.                      | A real route to an online outlet.                            | Usually a station inbox, not a named programming decision-maker.                         |
| <b>Music submission contact</b>    | A station page explicitly invites music or provides a music-role address.              | High use-case relevance when dated and traceable.            | May still be shared or change over time; label only what the source states.              |
| <b>Named programming contact</b>   | A public source identifies a person and programming title.                             | The strongest fit for the original promise.                  | Requires current role confirmation; a historic title cannot be silently carried forward. |

### ■ INSIGHT — Real is not the same as relevant.

The original product treated existence as sufficient. A defensible outreach directory needs a second filter: does this contact route match the buyer's intended action, and is the role described no more strongly than the source?

## 2.11 Recurring Zazie Productions Product Pattern

RadioReach was not isolated from the broader Zazie Productions style. It used the same combination of volume, dramatic naming, outsider identity, public-information repackaging, and rapid platform deployment visible across other products and profiles.

- **Vault language:** large bundles are framed as rare, forbidden, hidden, banned, cursed, or exclusive — turning quantity into mystique.
- **Esoteric technical density:** specialized terms and elaborate titles create aesthetic authority before utility is evaluated.
- **Cross-domain halo:** real music, radio, design, and research activity makes unrelated commercial expertise feel pre-validated.
- **Low-ticket impulse model:** inexpensive files are paired with high-energy copy, reducing the financial threshold for skepticism.
- **Platform multiplication:** one release, product, or biography is distributed across many services, creating ambient ubiquity.
- **Anti-gatekeeping narrative:** products are positioned as liberation from institutions while still borrowing institutional language, awards, press, and verification cues.
- **Fast launch / slow maintenance:** naming and packaging mature earlier than update systems, customer support, legal documentation, and evidence maintenance.

The pattern contains a legitimate business model: public information can become valuable when it is cleaned, organized, filtered, and maintained. The failure occurs when curation is marketed as proprietary access, archival presence is marketed as current verification, or theatrical rarity substitutes for quality control.

### ■ INSIGHT — The recurring tension is curation versus alchemy.

Curation honestly adds organization and judgment. Signal-stacking tries to transform ordinary public material into elite access, institutional recognition, or secret expertise through language and presentation alone.

## 2.12 The RadioReach Rebuild

The repair process changed the governing question from “How can the original scale be defended?” to “Which records are fair to place in front of a paying customer, under what role label, and with what limitation?”

| Term                      | Definition                                                                                             | Real-World Example                                                             | In This Case Study                                                                  |
|---------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Source triage</b>      | The three unreliable mega-document buckets were excluded.                                              | Removes most of the apparently current scale.                                  | Prevents opaque inherited data from silently re-entering the product.               |
| <b>FCC acquisition</b>    | Full AM and partial FM public-file data were pulled from official APIs.                                | Adds genuine station records and dated government-filed contacts.              | Roles remain station contacts, not music directors.                                 |
| <b>Own research</b>       | Earlier independent and commercial research was recovered and deduplicated.                            | Preserves genuinely researched contacts that had fallen out of prior merges.   | Specialized roles remain only where the source supports them.                       |
| <b>Consumer filtering</b> | Australian newsroom rows and shared corporate compliance addresses were removed.                       | Drops real-but-wrong-use-case records.                                         | The buyer sees a cleaner outreach product rather than an internal research archive. |
| <b>Workable rule</b>      | A row qualifies with email, phone, or a named contact.                                                 | Phone-only rows remain available instead of being fabricated into email leads. | Missing fields stay visibly blank or use an em dash.                                |
| <b>Role normalization</b> | FCC and internet source terminology became Station Contact; explicit submission roles remain specific. | Removes audit jargon and role inflation at the same time.                      | The role column now describes customer use rather than source prestige.             |
| <b>Extraction repair</b>  | 392 internet-station names and 17 wrapped email addresses were repaired from parser residue.           | Improves presentation without inventing new data.                              | The clean source now drives PDF, XLSX, and CSV outputs.                             |

### ■ INSIGHT — The ethical pivot was methodological, not cosmetic.

Changing “FCC Main Studio Contact” to “Station Contact” improved customer language, but the more important repair was excluding unsupported buckets and letting the actual filtered file determine the public count.

## 2.13 Current MVP Snapshot

The internal research corpus and the customer product now serve different purposes. The internal database retains source tiers and audit fields; the consumer deliverables expose one clean directory without implying that every row has the same role, age, or verification pathway.

| Term                      | Definition                                                                                                       | Real-World Example                                                      | In This Case Study                                                          |
|---------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Internal corpus</b>    | 10,454 deduplicated records across government, own research, secondary, internet, and excluded press categories. | Useful for research, sourcing, and future updates.                      | Not all rows are suitable for the customer MVP.                             |
| <b>Consumer total</b>     | 6,568 workable contacts.                                                                                         | Every row has email, phone, or a named contact after current filtering. | This is the count shipped in the synchronized PDF/XLSX/CSV.                 |
| <b>Email present</b>      | 6,087 rows.                                                                                                      | An email route exists in the file.                                      | Presence is not a permanent mailbox-level guarantee.                        |
| <b>Named contact</b>      | 4,119 rows.                                                                                                      | A person's name appears in the record.                                  | A name does not automatically establish a music-programming role.           |
| <b>Phone present</b>      | 4,600 rows.                                                                                                      | A callable route is available, including phone-only station records.    | Formatting and ownership can still change.                                  |
| <b>U.S. broadcast</b>     | 4,559 station contacts from official-file data, including phone-only rows.                                       | Strong station authenticity.                                            | Not complete nationwide FM coverage and not a directory of music directors. |
| <b>College / indie</b>    | 369 researched college, community, specialty, or submission contacts.                                            | Higher music-outreach relevance in a smaller bucket.                    | Age and mailbox monitoring still require maintenance.                       |
| <b>Internet / webcast</b> | 1,640 online-station contacts across U.S. and international markets.                                             | Broadens format and geography.                                          | Mostly station-level inboxes rather than named people.                      |

The customer package now includes a 210-page branded directory, a one-sheet XLSX workbook, a matching CSV, and a two-page overview. All derive from the same 6,568-row clean source, eliminating count drift among the new customer deliverables; any live sales page, sample, or advertisement must still be synchronized separately.

## 2.14 Residual Risks & Unresolved Claims

The rebuild created a defensible MVP, not a permanently verified database or a completed path back to the old headline. Several risks remain and should be explicit in any future version.

| Term                        | Definition                                                                                  | Real-World Example                                                                   | In This Case Study                                                                             |
|-----------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Public-copy mismatch</b> | Historic site or ad claims may still exceed the rebuilt artifact.                           | Customers compare the sales promise to the shipped file, not the private build plan. | Every live page, sample, ad, and checkout description must eventually use synchronized totals. |
| <b>“Verified” branding</b>  | The product name can imply mailbox or role verification beyond the actual inclusion rule.   | Brand language can re-inflate a carefully limited dataset.                           | Define verified prominently or consider a less ambiguous product descriptor.                   |
| <b>Freshness</b>            | Staff, phones, and mailboxes change continuously.                                           | A one-time clean is not a maintenance system.                                        | Add review dates, refresh cycles, correction intake, and version history.                      |
| <b>FM incompleteness</b>    | The FCC pull covered all available AM in the run but only part of the much larger FM index. | The U.S. broadcast bucket is substantial but not complete.                           | Do not say every licensed U.S. AM and FM station.                                              |
| <b>Mailbox certainty</b>    | Email syntax and domain viability are not individual acceptance guarantees.                 | Even accepted mailboxes may be unmonitored or irrelevant.                            | Separate email-present, MX-checked, SMTP-tested, and human-confirmed categories.               |
| <b>Role certainty</b>       | Station Contact is accurate but broad.                                                      | Broad labels protect honesty while limiting the original decision-maker promise.     | Grow specialized-role coverage through direct station pages and dated staff verification.      |
| <b>Third-party listings</b> | Internet-station data derives from public listing pages and extraction.                     | Listings can be real yet stale or shared.                                            | Retain source date, deduplicate shared inboxes, and schedule refreshes.                        |

### ■ INSIGHT — The rebuild should not become a new halo.

A polished 6,568-row product is real progress. It does not retroactively validate the old 18,020/10,372 claims, and it should not be described as fully current, individually verified, or nationally complete until those separate standards are actually met.

## PART III

# The Glossary of Growth-Hacking & Persona-Engineering Terms

Each term below is presented with a plain-language definition, a real-world example independent of the case study, and the specific place it appeared in RadioReach / Zazie Productions.

## 3.1 Search & Web Visibility

| Term                                           | Definition                                                                                 | Real-World Example                                              | In This Case Study                                                                                                         |
|------------------------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>SEO (grey-hat)</b>                          | Search optimization tactics that sit between fully honest and fully manipulative.          | Publishing thin content mainly to rank for a keyword.           | LinkedIn lists actual SEO/keyword-optimization coursework; the broad footprint also functions as search-result management. |
| <b>Reputation management / SERP domination</b> | Deliberately owning enough search results that one preferred narrative dominates.          | A company seeding many positive profiles after bad press.       | Many independent-looking platform pages reinforce the same polymath/creator narrative.                                     |
| <b>Private blog network (PBN) / link farm</b>  | Clusters of low-quality sites that cite or republish one another to simulate authority.    | Generic news sites all pointing to the same promotional source. | Not proven as a formal PBN here; adjacent to the press-mill and cross-republication pattern.                               |
| <b>Content mill</b>                            | Low-cost, high-volume production of articles or products with limited editorial standards. | Clickbait listicle farms and template-driven product catalogs.  | The large Gumroad/itch.io catalog and high-volume entertainment-profile ecosystem show content-mill characteristics.       |
| <b>Typosquatting / brandjacking</b>            | Using a name designed to be confused with an established institution or trademark.         | A near-copy of a famous brand name used to borrow trust.        | GrammyWeekly-style naming creates prestige by proximity despite no Recording Academy affiliation.                          |

| Term                         | Definition                                                                                       | Real-World Example                                                       | In This Case Study                                                                                  |
|------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Pink slime journalism</b> | Template-driven sites that mimic real journalism without comparable reporting or accountability. | A generic local-news network publishing sponsored profiles as reporting. | Brand-adjacent artist-profile sites and house bylines resemble a publish-anyone editorial pipeline. |

## 3.2 Media & Press Manipulation

| Term                                                 | Definition                                                                          | Real-World Example                                                     | In This Case Study                                                                                                       |
|------------------------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Astroturfing</b>                                  | Manufacturing the appearance of organic grassroots approval.                        | Coordinated fake product reviews.                                      | RadioReach's stock-photo-style verified-buyer testimonials created apparent customer consensus.                          |
| <b>Native advertising / advertorial</b>              | Paid or submitted promotional material designed to look like independent editorial. | A sponsored founder profile presented as a news story.                 | Some artist-profile placements read as journalism while operating through submission-driven channels.                    |
| <b>Pay-to-play press</b>                             | Paying directly or through a package for guaranteed or highly likely coverage.      | A magazine that profiles nearly any paying advertiser.                 | Relevant to brand-adjacent profile outlets and promotional-placement ecosystems used in the footprint.                   |
| <b>Source-pitching platforms (HARO/Qwoted model)</b> | Tools where people pitch themselves as expert sources for roundups and quotes.      | A marketer quoted in a trend piece through a journalist-request email. | The Viral Nation quote and PR ON THE GO expert roundup fit this access model.                                            |
| <b>Vanity press / vanity award</b>                   | Publication or recognition available through low-barrier submission or payment.     | A Who's Who directory listing most applicants.                         | Some press/award language compresses finalists, small juried mentions, and self-serve placement into prestige shorthand. |
| <b>Byline farming</b>                                | A small pool of house names used across high volumes of unrelated content.          | One staff identity publishing on dozens of unrelated subjects.         | The same GrammyWeekly-style byline appears across unrelated celebrity and unsigned-artist profiles.                      |

| Term               | Definition                                                                                | Real-World Example                                                   | In This Case Study                                                                                            |
|--------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Citogenesis</b> | A self-originated claim is repeated until repetition looks like independent confirmation. | A bio claim gets copied by directories, then cited back as a source. | Inflated biography language is re-stated across profiles, reinforcing one underlying self-authored narrative. |

### 3.3 Social Proof Fabrication

| Term                                    | Definition                                                                                  | Real-World Example                                          | In This Case Study                                                                                                |
|-----------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Sockpuppeting</b>                    | One person operates multiple identities to simulate independent agreement.                  | A founder reviewing a product under several fake accounts.  | Not directly confirmed here; structurally adjacent to unverifiable buyer testimonials.                            |
| <b>Fake / manufactured testimonials</b> | Endorsements attributed to people who did not provide them or cannot be authenticated.      | A supplement ad using stock photos as real customers.       | RadioReach used named five-star verified-buyer testimonials whose visual identities appeared to be stock imagery. |
| <b>Engagement / follower inflation</b>  | Bots, purchased followers, or engagement exchanges create an exaggerated popularity signal. | A social account purchasing 50,000 followers overnight.     | Not established in this case; self-reported reach should remain separate from third-party-confirmed metrics.      |
| <b>Vanity metrics</b>                   | Real or simulated numbers that look impressive but do not establish the claimed outcome.    | Millions of impressions with no sales or retention context. | A live viewer counter, license counter, raw row count, and platform count all functioned as prestige metrics.     |

### 3.4 Persuasion & Sales Psychology

| Term                  | Definition                                                  | Real-World Example        | In This Case Study                                                  |
|-----------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------|---------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Scarcity</b>       | Signaling limited availability to increase perceived value. | Only three left in stock. | RadioReach claimed a limited number of licenses for a digital file. |
| <b>Urgency / FOMO</b> | Time pressure that short-circuits deliberation.             | Sale ends at midnight.    | The founder-price countdown pushed purchase before source checking. |

| Term                         | Definition                                                                             | Real-World Example                               | In This Case Study                                                                                   |
|------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Social proof</b>          | Other people's apparent approval is used to justify trust.                             | Fifty thousand five-star reviews.                | Testimonials and a live-viewer counter implied prior buyer validation.                               |
| <b>Authority bias</b>        | Claims feel stronger because the source looks expert or institutional.                 | A lab coat used to sell supplements.             | The broad creative/radio footprint and technical-looking PDF gave the database an authority halo.    |
| <b>Anchoring</b>             | An inflated reference value makes the asking price feel unusually cheap.               | Was \$500, now \$99.                             | A claimed \$742 value was contrasted with the \$20 price.                                            |
| <b>Loss aversion</b>         | Inaction is framed as a loss, which can motivate more strongly than a gain.            | Don't miss your chance.                          | Price-increase and expiring-founder-offer copy made waiting feel costly.                             |
| <b>Halo effect</b>           | One positive trait causes unrelated positive traits to be assumed.                     | A famous athlete used to endorse finance advice. | Real creative work and radio experience made unrelated database-verification claims feel safer.      |
| <b>Illusory truth effect</b> | Repetition increases perceived truth independent of evidence.                          | A rumor becoming common knowledge.               | The same identity and achievement language repeated across many self-created or derivative profiles. |
| <b>Dark patterns</b>         | Interface choices engineered to manipulate action rather than support informed choice. | A hidden cancel button.                          | Countdowns, scarcity, and activity counters increased pressure while reducing scrutiny.              |

### 3.5 Business & Marketing Model Terms

| Term                                        | Definition                                                                | Real-World Example                                            | In This Case Study                                                                                          |
|---------------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Direct response marketing</b>            | Advertising built to provoke an immediate action or purchase.             | A late-night infomercial.                                     | The RadioReach landing page moved directly from pain and proof to urgency and checkout.                     |
| <b>VSL structure / AIDA framework</b>       | Attention, Interest, Desire, Action arranged as a persuasion sequence.    | Problem-agitate-solve copy.                                   | Problem agitation, testimonials, stacked value, urgency, FAQ, and a binary close.                           |
| <b>Growth hacking</b>                       | Aggressive, low-cost tactics for rapid audience or visibility growth.     | Referral loops and systematic free-platform outreach.         | Working many open submissions, profile platforms, quote systems, and storefronts over time.                 |
| <b>Info-product funnel / guru marketing</b> | A cheap digital product sold through hype-heavy, urgency-driven copy.     | A make-money course sold from a webinar.                      | RadioReach and recurring vault-style product branding fit the low-ticket info-product pattern.              |
| <b>Personal branding</b>                    | Deliberate construction of a public identity as a strategic asset.        | A consultant maintaining a consistent thought-leader persona. | The autistic polymath / outsider-artist frame appears consistently across bios and ventures.                |
| <b>Puffery</b>                              | Subjective promotional exaggeration not normally treated as literal fact. | The best coffee in town.                                      | Award-winning, forbidden, cursed, black-ops, and underground language often functions as aesthetic puffery. |

### 3.6 Music-Industry-Specific Terms

| Term          | Definition                                        | Real-World Example               | In This Case Study                                                                                             |
|---------------|---------------------------------------------------|----------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Payola</b> | Undisclosed payment for guaranteed radio airplay. | The historic Alan Freed scandal. | RadioReach's premise reflects the same access problem, although selling contact research is not itself payola. |

| Term                 | Definition                                                                                                  | Real-World Example                               | In This Case Study                                                                                                   |
|----------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Song plugging</b> | A representative personally pitches songs to radio, publishers, or tastemakers.                             | A publisher's rep visiting stations with a demo. | A current, accurately labeled contact directory would support modern do-it-yourself song plugging.                   |
| <b>Pay-to-play</b>   | Artists pay for access, feedback, performance, or consideration rather than being selected solely on merit. | A venue charging bands for a slot.               | Groover and SubmitHub-style curator submissions are fee-based access channels, not guaranteed independent discovery. |

### 3.7 Platform-Specific Manipulation

| Term                                | Definition                                                               | Real-World Example                                 | In This Case Study                                                                                           |
|-------------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Playlist plugging schemes</b>    | Payment for guaranteed or bot-inflated playlist placement.               | A gig promising 10,000 streams.                    | Not established here; relevant because legitimate curation and paid access exist in the same ecosystem.      |
| <b>Follow-back / follow-churn</b>   | Mass-following accounts to trigger reciprocal follows, then unfollowing. | An automated social growth service.                | Not directly confirmed; included as a common adjacent growth tactic.                                         |
| <b>Click farms / stream botting</b> | Workers or automation generate fake plays, likes, or views.              | Documented streaming-fraud rings.                  | Not confirmed; third-party-confirmed playlist following should be separated from any unverified reach claim. |
| <b>Wiki-washing</b>                 | Creating or managing a Wikipedia-style page to manufacture notability.   | A company paying editors for a flattering article. | Not observed; no Wikipedia page was part of the audited stack.                                               |

#### ■ INSIGHT — “Signal-stacking” is the single best umbrella term.

Every other tactic in this glossary produces one more credibility signal for the stack. No single signal would convince a careful reader alone; the effect works in aggregate, especially when the reader never checks the source, selection standard, or verification method behind any one piece.

### 3.8 Meta-Terms & Metaphors

| Term                    | Definition                                                                                       | Real-World Example                                              | In This Case Study                                                                                                 |
|-------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Signal-stacking</b>  | Accumulating many weak-but-plausible signals until their aggregate feels authoritative.          | A resume padded with many low-value bullets.                    | The cross-platform footprint, press, metrics, products, and credentials functioned as one unified trust signal.    |
| <b>Potemkin metrics</b> | Impressive-looking numbers conceal that the measured category is weak or irrelevant.             | A huge user count with no active-user denominator.              | 18,020 rows and exact viewer/license counters looked rigorous while obscuring contact usability and role accuracy. |
| <b>Cargo cult</b>       | Copying the visible outputs of a legitimate process without the process that gives them meaning. | Imitating a laboratory's appearance without controlled testing. | Verified language, press styling, awards, and polished tables mimicked the outputs of real vetting.                |

PART IV

# The Layer Model — What's Actually Behind a “Persona”

The Zazie Productions case can be described as a stack of distinct layers, built in roughly this order. Each layer can be independently true, independently false, or simply irrelevant to the layers around it.

| Layer   | What It Is                                                                                                      | Example From Case Study                                                                                            |
|---------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Layer 0 | The real human core: an actual person with real skills, motives, history, and an origin story.                  | Real music-making, radio experience, technical fluency, niche curation, and sustained creative work.               |
| Layer 1 | Genuine low-barrier achievements: work that required effort but little external gatekeeping.                    | Bandcamp releases, self-published digital products, storefronts, and portfolio profiles.                           |
| Layer 2 | Systematized visibility: one action automatically multiplies into many digital traces.                          | A distributor upload appearing across streaming services, metadata sites, and scraper profiles.                    |
| Layer 3 | Manufactured or pay-adjacent credibility: submission-driven press, expert roundups, and brand-adjacent outlets. | GrammyWeekly-style profiles, PR ON THE GO quotes, and SubmitHub-accessed coverage.                                 |
| Layer 4 | Persuasion engineering: urgency, rhetorical inflation, and value framing convert attention into money or trust. | RadioReach's countdown, license scarcity, testimonials, exact verification counts, and stacked value.              |
| Layer 5 | Audience psychology: halo effect, anchoring, social proof, and illusory truth make the stack feel coherent.     | A buyer treating real radio experience and a polished footprint as evidence that every database claim was checked. |
| Layer 6 | Outcome: ambient, hard-to-challenge trust independent of whether each underlying layer holds up.                | The feeling that the seller is too prolific, established, or underground-famous to question over a \$20 purchase.  |

■ **INSIGHT — The layers are independently gradable — and that's the whole point.**

Layers 0 and 1 contain substantial real work. Layer 3 contains weak or manufactured authority signals. Layer 4 converted the total impression into a sale. The persona did not need every layer to be false; it only needed enough layers that casual viewers would not inspect their different standards.

## Hidden Insights From This Investigation

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### ■ INSIGHT — 1. Wide presence is not the same as vetted presence.

Profiles across IMDb, LinkedIn, Bandcamp, Gumroad, itch.io, stores, and streaming platforms prove persistence and distribution. Most are self-submitted. The legitimacy feeling comes from volume, not a shared vetting standard.

### ■ INSIGHT — 2. The most useful test is category consistency.

A precise number can remain numerically stable while its meaning drifts: rows become contacts, contacts become deliverable emails, and deliverable emails become human decision-makers. The category must be checked, not only the number.

### ■ INSIGHT — 3. Brand-adjacent names transfer trust before the reader investigates affiliation.

An outlet name that evokes the Grammys or a major trade publication borrows authority immediately. A disclaimer or lack of explicit affiliation rarely cancels the first impression.

### ■ INSIGHT — 4. A high-volume house byline is a content-pipeline fingerprint.

One byline covering global celebrities, niche artists, and unrelated subjects in the same promotional register is evidence of a publication system, not a beat reporter independently discovering every subject.

### ■ INSIGHT — 5. Technically true language can be more durable than an outright fabrication.

Verified, award-winning, featured, and deliverable can each be narrowly defended while implying something larger. That ambiguity makes the claim harder to challenge and easier to repeat.

### ■ INSIGHT — 6. Free tools can unwind an elaborate credibility stack.

WHOIS, DNS/MX checks, PDF extraction, archive searches, and third-party trackers were enough to distinguish real achievements, self-serve visibility, stale data, and contradicted claims.

■ **INSIGHT — 7. Perceived unapproachability can suppress accountability.**

A prolific, prestigious, or underground-famous persona makes an ordinary refund request or factual correction feel socially presumptuous. Mystique therefore helps both conversion and post-purchase silence.

■ **INSIGHT — 8. Persistence is the scarce resource — not secret knowledge.**

The stack was built through years of repeated submissions, uploads, profile creation, naming, and packaging. The same persistence can be redirected toward dated sources, maintenance, and independently checkable outcomes.

■ **INSIGHT — 9. Repair becomes possible when identity and artifact are separated.**

RadioReach could shrink from its original headline to a 6,568-row workable MVP without erasing the real creative career behind Zazie Productions. A corrected product is not the destruction of the person who made it.

# Practical Checklist — How To Audit Any Persona Yourself

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## Step 1 — Establish the timeline

- Run a WHOIS lookup on any associated domain. Note the registration date — a domain days or weeks old carries zero track record regardless of how the site looks.
- Check the Wayback Machine ([web.archive.org](http://web.archive.org)) for historical snapshots. No history at all confirms a brand-new operation; a long history with a recent pivot (e.g., a rebrand) is its own red flag.

## Step 2 — Test the checkable claims, not the vibe

- If a product claims “verified” data, sample a few specific entries and check them independently (e.g., does the named contact still hold that job, according to an unrelated third-party source?).
- If email addresses are involved, DNS/MX checks can mathematically prove a domain cannot receive mail — no need to actually send anything.
- Look for company/brand names in the data (e.g., email domains) that stopped existing under that name years ago — a strong, checkable signal of stale, recycled data.

## Step 3 — Compare numbers across sources

- Find the same metric (followers, revenue, years in business) stated in two or more places. Consistency is reassuring; drift — especially only-upward drift — is a strong tell.
- Prefer numbers confirmable via an independent, non-affiliated third-party tracker over self-reported figures.

## Step 4 — Investigate the press, not just the coverage

- Check whether an outlet's name closely resembles a famous trademark (Billboard, Grammy, Rolling Stone, Forbes). Search “[outlet name] affiliated with [real brand]” directly.
- Search the author byline against other, unrelated articles. A byline covering wildly different beats in identical language across many pieces indicates a content mill, not a reporter.
- Check the outlet's own “submit,” “advertise,” or “contributor” pages — an openly self-serve submission pipeline undercuts any implied editorial vetting.

## Step 5 — Separate the layers

- For each credential/claim, ask: was this the result of real, accountable gatekeeping (a jury, an editor who could reject it, a peer-reviewed process), or a self-serve, low-barrier, or paid channel?
- A persona built entirely from Tier 3 (self-serve) credentials, with no Tier 1 anchor anywhere, is the strongest red flag — even if every individual piece is technically real.

## Step 6 — Watch for the absence of friction

- No visible controversy, no critical mentions anywhere, and no public pushback can be a genuinely good sign — or simply mean not enough people have looked yet, especially for very new operations.
- Conversely, an active backlash (diss tracks, complaint threads, defensive rebuttal content from the subject) is a strong, if uncomfortable, signal worth weighing heavily.

## **Step 7 — Just ask, directly**

The single most underused verification step: contact the real, identifiable person behind the persona directly and specifically. A real, findable, reachable individual (verified via WHOIS/registration records matching a real identity) has genuine accountability exposure and often responds reasonably when confronted with specific, documented discrepancies — which is a meaningfully different situation from chasing an anonymous or fabricated identity that cannot be found at all.

# Alphabetical Quick-Reference Glossary

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- Advertorial
- Anchoring
- Astroturfing
- Authority bias
- Brandjacking
- Byline farming
- Cargo cult
- Checkbook journalism
- Citogenesis
- Click farms / stream botting
- Content mill
- Dark patterns
- Direct response marketing
- Doorway pages
- Engagement pods
- Fake / manufactured testimonials
- Follow-churn schemes
- Growth hacking
- Guru marketing
- Halo effect
- Illusory truth effect
- Info-product funnel
- Keyword stuffing
- Loss aversion
- Native advertising
- Negative SEO
- Parasite SEO
- Pay-to-play (music venues)
- Pay-to-play (press)
- Payola
- Personal branding
- Pink slime journalism
- Playlist plugging schemes
- Potemkin village / Potemkin metrics
- Private blog network (PBN)
- Puffery
- Reputation management / SERP domination
- Scarcity
- SEO (grey-hat / black-hat)
- Signal-stacking
- Social proof
- Sockpuppeting
- Song plugging
- Source-pitching platforms (HARO/Qwoted model)
- Sponsored content evasion
- Typosquatting
- Urgency / FOMO
- Vanity metrics
- Vanity press / vanity award
- VSL structure / AIDA framework
- Wiki-washing

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**A closing note on method, not judgment:** every finding in this guide traces back to a specific, citable, publicly accessible source — a WHOIS record, a DNS query, an extracted PDF, an archived web page, or a cross-referenced third-party tracker. Nothing here relies on speculation about private intent. The purpose of naming these mechanisms is defensive: once a technique has a name, it becomes far easier to notice the next time it's used on you.